

EARLY MODERN SIEGE WARFARE

THE SIEGE OF NAMUR

During French King Louis XIV's reign (1643–1715), sieges were the most characteristic operations in European warfare. The Siege of Namur in 1692 is a famous example of this formalized combat, which was led by military engineers who designed the fortifications and also conducted the sieges.

Namur in Flanders was a strongpoint of the Grand Alliance (comprising the British, Dutch, Austrians, and Spanish), opponents of the French during the Nine Years' War. The fortified town stood on a plain on the north bank of the River Sambre; the citadel – an elaborate complex of fortifications – was set on rocky heights behind the town, on the south bank of the river.

In May 1692, King Louis came to witness his army's siege of Namur, led by his master engineer, the Marquis de Vauban. The fortress's defence was organized by Vauban's rival, Dutch engineer Menno van Coehoorn.

Vauban followed his standard procedures: beginning on 25 May, two lines of earthworks were dug encircling Namur. These were both to blockade the town and protect the French, who were encamped between the lines, against attack from an Alliance relief army. Then, within this encirclement, men dug lines of zig-zag trenches, or saps, toward the weakest point of the fortification. At intervals a transverse trench, or parallel, was dug and positions created for gun batteries. The cannon were then moved forward to the parallel, thus steadily advancing toward the fortress. The initial aim of the French batteries was to clear the fortifications of artillery. Vauban used ricochet fire, sending cannon balls bouncing into the defences, to force defenders to abandon their positions.

The town's low-lying fortifications, fronted by a ditch and a glacis (a slope at the fortification's base), offered a minimal target while giving defenders a clear field of fire: the French troops in their trenches were bombarded by explosive shells lobbed by high-trajectory mortars and howitzers.

Despite heavy fire, the French trenches were able to be dug close enough for troops to batter a breach in the walls with their siege guns; once the breach was opened, the defenders negotiated the surrender of the town.

THE FIGHT FOR THE CITADEL

The siege was not over, however, for the garrison withdrew to the citadel, where the fighting resumed in earnest. Under the surrender terms the French agreed not to attack the citadel from the side nearest the town, where the defences were weakest. Instead they had to overcome an elaborate series of outworks fronting the main citadel.

Coehoorn directed the defence of the strongest of these, Fort William, in person. While Vauban dug his saps and parallels, French mortars bombarded the defenders with explosive shells launched over the walls. On 22 June, after a French infantry assault, Coehoorn surrendered the fort and was taken prisoner. The main citadel, however, remained unbreached.

The French, meanwhile, had run into supply difficulties: without sufficient fodder, their many thousands of horses began to starve. Persistent wet weather had also turned the ground to a quagmire and carts trying to bring heavy ammunition up to the batteries foundered. It was a profound relief to Vauban and his king when the citadel's defences were breached with sudden ease – possibly through an act of betrayal from within the garrison, which somehow left a section of the fortifications undefended. The garrison formally capitulated on 30 June and was granted the honours of war, marching out with drums beating and banners flying.

